

Palace of Westminster

London's old Houses of Parliament, which burned down in 1834, dated back to the 12th century, and the fire provided an opportunity to replace them with a modern structure suitable for governing Britain. In 1833, noted architect Charles Barry (1795–1860) won a competition to create the new building. During construction, he came to rely heavily on Pugin; while Barry favoured classicism, Pugin added many Gothic stylings. The façade of sand-coloured Yorkshire limestone stretches along the Thames for 289 metres (914 ft), and the vast building incorporates grand assembly chambers as well as committee rooms, kitchens, offices and libraries. The building is dominated by two towers: the huge Victoria Tower and the soaring Clock Tower, known as Big Ben after the great bell inside it. The decorative Clock Tower, finials and turrets were largely designed by Pugin, who added ogees (double curves) and carved crockets (leaf-like elements bordering spires and roofs). Pugin was also in charge of the Gothic-styled interiors, and supplied designs for furnishings.

